

An AI CoE that can say no

The anatomy of an AI Center of Excellence: what it owns, what it only advises on, how it gets funded, and the four ways it quietly stops governing. **Same framework as the episode – one page, no video required.**

WHAT IT OWNS vs what it only advises on

ADVISES ON

Pattern choice, roadmap order, prompt design. A good opinion – the team can take it or leave it, because the real decision sits elsewhere.

OWNS

A verdict nobody can route around, no matter how senior the sponsor is. If every "no" is just advice, nothing is actually governed.

Six decision rights map to this (full list: Season 1 Episode 2). The one that matters most is who approves a use case before it's built. **If the CoE only advises on that one, it doesn't control what gets built.**

THE FUNDING TEST how it's paid decides whether it can refuse

PROJECT-FUNDED

Chargeback, or a budget renewed on utilization. Every use case parked is a line that doesn't get charged and doesn't get logged.

STANDING CAPABILITY

A base budget set once at the portfolio level. Renewed on outcomes, so refusing something costs nobody their funding.

A function paid per approved project can't be expected to keep saying no. **Standing funding is what makes refusing possible.**

FOUR WAYS IT BREAKS you'll recognize at least one

IVORY TOWER

Detailed standards, and almost nothing ships.

BOTTLENECK

A real gate, too slow. Teams quietly build around it.

RUBBER STAMP

Zero requests ever declined, which is a warning sign.

SHADOW COE

Real approvals happen in private chats, off the register.

THE THREE ARTEFACTS each one can be checked

USE-CASE REGISTER

Every request that came through intake, including the parked and the declined, so it can be audited.

PATTERN LIBRARY

Vetted building blocks for new work. The test is whether teams use them.

MODEL & AGENT INVENTORY

What is live, who owns it, which autonomy tier. If you can't answer that in minutes, you don't have one.

THE METRICS IT REPORTS ON ITSELF which set it reports

VANITY

Workshops delivered. Pilots launched. Satisfaction scored by the same teams whose requests it approved. A CoE that approves everything scores well on all three.

REAL

Share of intake declined or parked last quarter, reason on file. Median days to verdict. Production agents with a named owner, checked today.

MONDAY MORNING two minutes, no meeting

1 Find one real decline

Pull your intake log. One request, actually told no.

– One that was declined outright. If you find it, read the reason on file.

2 If you can't find one

Don't decline something just to prove a point.

– Write one sentence: what would make you say no to the next request that walks in.

OPERATOR INSIGHT · EPISODE 5

"A center of excellence that cannot say no is a service desk with a better name."

"Your AI maturity will never exceed your operational maturity."

Free

Score your own use-case gate – the same decision right and funding test, against your own systems.

vihrenlabs.gumroad.com/l/rmkje